

Unlike many doctors, my paternal grandfather was largely uninterested in money. He did a great deal of charity work and academic medicine, but he didn't care for business or money. When his private practice patients couldn't pay, he simply cared for them anyway. When he sent out bills that went unpaid, he ignored rebilling or collection attempts. He was thought of by myriad people as saintly for his kind, warm, and generous persona. Fortunately for his immediate family, he had Aunt Cary to “secretly” bankroll him behind the scenes. Without Cary, you likely would never have gotten this book.

Father was originally privately tutored. My grandfather didn't believe in the elementary schools of the day, and Aunt Cary could afford better. Later, Father was enrolled in San Francisco's prestigious Lowell High School. He graduated at age sixteen. Smart, too young, well educated from tutoring, Father was also awkward and lacking in social skills other children normally learn in elementary school. He was frail, brittle, and uncoordinated sports-wise; and being young by comparison, he was small relative to Lowell classmates. So he felt socially insecure, which was furthered by his mother's incessantly critical and negative nature. At sixteen, Father started at UC-Berkeley; but later, with financial aid from Aunt Cary and a car paid for by her, he transferred to smaller and friendlier Stanford University. That transfer also proved fateful.

He dutifully returned to San Francisco on weekends, which began with a ritual Friday night family dinner at Aunt Cary's and Uncle Henry's. These dinners spanned almost fifty years, starting before Father's birth, and included even distant family members. The dinners were central to building Father's early social skills. (The ritual still existed briefly when I was a child.) My grandparents always attended. Father arrived directly from Berkeley or later Stanford. Cary's house, which if it existed today would be called a mansion, was built in the 1890's by Uncle Henry on Jackson Street, just off Van Ness. The multi-course feast involved much discourse and after-dinner debate that often turned various family participants combative, something my grandfather loved watching. There were lots of child-aged females; but as the only male of his generation, Father became a particular favorite of Uncle Henry, which made these events particularly memorable to father—his one chance as a young man to stand out in a crowd. After